Use the Surface Area Formulas

You will be expected to find the surface areas of rectangular prisms, pyramids, cylinders, cones, and spheres. To make your work easier, the GED math formula sheet includes formulas for finding the surface areas of these figures.

Surface Area (*SA*) Formulas
(p = perimeter of base, B = area of the base,
h = height, r = radius, s = slant height)

Rectangular/Right Prism	SA	=	$ph + 2B$
Cylinder	SA	=	$2\pi rh + 2\pi r^2$
Square Pyramid	SA	=	$\frac{1}{2}ps + B$
Cone	SA	=	$\pi rs + \pi r^2$
Sphere	SA	=	$4\pi r^2$

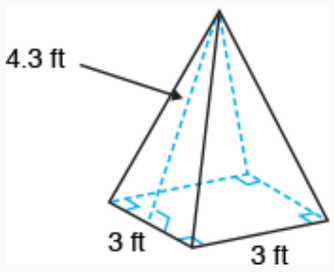
Remember, a formula uses algebra to write a procedure for doing something. These formulas add the areas of the faces of a figure. You don't have to use formulas, but they may save you time.

Example

Hide

Find the surface area of the pyramid.

Use the formula: $SA = \frac{1}{2}ps + B$



Step 1
Find the facts you need to use the formula.
The slant height s is 4.3 feet.
Find p, the perimeter of the base: $3 + 3 + 3 + 3 = 12$
Find B, the area of the base: $3^2 = 9$
Step 2
Evaluate the formula.

$$SA = \frac{1}{2}ps + B$$
$$= \frac{1}{2} \cdot 12 \cdot 4.3 + 9$$
$$= \mathbf{34.8\ sq\ ft}$$

The surface area is **34.8 sq ft.**

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Lesson 5: Surface Area

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